



FUN BREAK: Villagers enjoy a cock fight in Dantewada

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To come by a police officer in uniform is a rare sight in Chhattisgarh. Maoist terror has seemingly redefined the law enforcer's dress code. Rahul Singh, superintendent of police, Dantewada, adheres to the new norm after 12 of his men were killed by the Maoists in December 2007. Dantewada is among eight highly disturbed districts in the country which the Prime Minister's Office has shortlisted for urgent developmental projects. Singh, however, argues that development cannot progress alongside conflict. "Socio-economic problems have taken a backseat here. The urgency of a full war at hand has not dawned upon the authorities yet," he says.

Chhattisgarh's police infrastructure is weak. The state is way below the national average of 54 police personnel required per 100 sq km. Police stations in far flung areas are not connected by telephones. In their biggest attack so far, Maoists killed 68 policemen including SPoS in Raniboldi on March 16 last year. B.S. Manekar is lodged in a Raipur prison charged under different sections of the IPC because 299 inmates, majority of who were reportedly Maoists, broke out of Dantewada jail a few weeks ago. The police suspect the then jail superintendent Manekar to be a Maoist sympathiser. The jail incidentally is almost inside a jungle and looks inadequate to even hold 100 people.

Even as questions over security infrastructure remain unanswered, legislation has been comprehended as a possible solution. Civil rights organisations disagree. In their opinion, the Chhattisgarh Special Public Security Act, 2006

is flawed. "This Act gives the state arbitrary powers to decide who is unlawful," Tuhin Deb of the Chhattisgarh Nagarik Paher says. Activists campaign for the release of academic Vinayak Sen who was arrested last May under the special act. Sen, the police claim, is a Maoist ideologue. "He was critical of the Salwa Judum and has been targeted for his views," his wife Ilina says.

The chief minister's house in Raipur is a fortress. Seated on a red chair and flanked by his dogs Lara and Leo, Raman Singh recommends political dialogue. "A dialogue at the national level might be the solution. This is a national problem and cannot be treated as law and order problems of the affected states," he says. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had asked chief ministers to take the matter seriously. "We need to cripple the hold of Naxalite forces with all the means at our command," he had said in Delhi last month. The political Left has distanced itself. In a draft resolution for the party's approaching congress in Coimbatore, the CPI (M) says, "The Maoists cannot be treated in any manner as a Left force as they harm the movement." Still, violence can't be contained by the might of the state alone. North Block cites "inadequacy of administrative and political institutions" as reason for the rise of this extremism. For the government, dialogue might be a reasonable addition to the gun. That, however, would require the Maoists to first disarm themselves. Next, the Government would have to rehabilitate them. At the moment, neither the Centre nor the Maoists are willing to talk, and the killing fields are expanding. ■